

Off the Shelf



The Hobbit

Visual appeal and entertainment aplenty

Most of you have seen the *Lord of the Rings* movies by now. It is truly amazing when you consider the detailed universe that this literary work of Tolkien has created. Especially if you are an RPG fan, most of the characters and locales you encounter owe their origins to this trilogy.

However, movies don't follow the book exactly, and this annoys purists.

So if you're interested in this world and want to know how it all began, *The Hobbit* is here to entertain you. Although no movie version exists to the book that preceded *LOTR*, there is a game at your disposal. Best of all, it sticks to the book.

The story goes thus. A group of Dwarves has been rendered homeless by an evil dragon called Smaug the Magnificent. Following the great loss and suffering across Middle-earth, the Dwarves decide to do something. They are accompanied by Gandalf, who recruits Bilbo Baggins to essay the role of a burglar and treasure-hunter extraordinaire. Now, Bilbo must endure a series of challenging quests.

The story is depicted nicely through

the use of storyboards, in-game cutscenes and voiceovers.

Once the quest begins, the game's visual appeal strikes you, despite the boring opening video. Butterflies in myriad colours circle the flora of Hobbiton, neat little gardens surround each Hobbit's home, and brightly coloured jewels and glowing silver pennies are yours to collect. All this is set to a very pleasant soundtrack.

The game has been developed by Inevitable Entertainment for consoles. Graphic effects such as fire and magical sparks are used liberally. Slamming your weapon down on an enemy results in a circle of light, and monsters go up in flames and a shower of gems. The game has got Arcade Console stamped all over it. This, and the depiction of Bilbo as a slightly overgrown kid, has resulted in the Everyone rating for the game.

As you progress, the game difficulty takes a sudden upward bump. Enemies attack in waves, more bosses are encountered, and the puzzles seem a hell of a lot more difficult. Abundant action saves the game from sliding the *Tomb Raider* way.

However, the action slacks in levels like The Gathering of



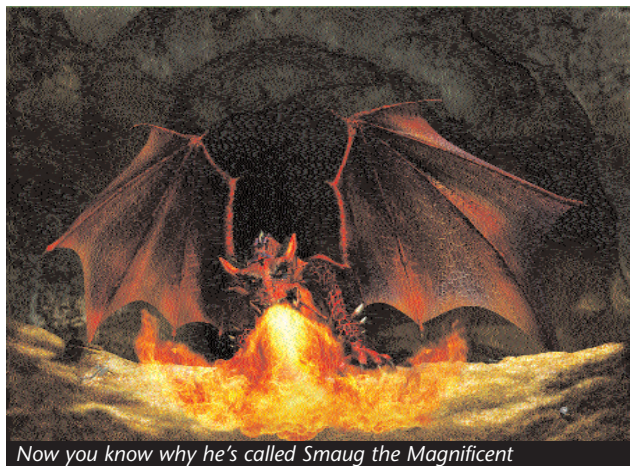
Bilbo gets a much-needed power-up

the Clouds, where enemies are few. At times like this, you need to take it easy for a while. Fortunately, the next level, The Clouds Burst is all-action, no puzzles. So you can merrily take on seven to eight goblins at a time, and show them who's boss.

By that time, you should have acquired the skills required to mutate from a timid Hobbit into a roaring ball of curly hair with big, hairy feet. The game is ported to the PC by a strange entity called The Fizz Factor, and they have had to grapple with the twin devils of camera controls, and the save system.

If you have a gamepad resembling a console, you will find that all is well. Otherwise, stick to a keyboard-mouse combination. The save system consists of pedestals where you can begin anew. The PC porting has also introduced a crashing bug that decides to present itself whenever the planets are aligned just so. You never know when it might strike.

When played at a stretch, *The Hobbit* can seem never-ending. But taken a session at a time, it provides plenty of entertainment, and is way above your everyday third-person slash-em-up.



Now you know why he's called Smaug the Magnificent

Genre: Action ■ **Developer:** Inevitable Entertainment/The Fizz Factor ■ **Publisher:** Vivendi Universal Games ■ **Distributor:** Sony Music Entertainment ■ **Phone:** 022-2646-1600 ■ **System Requirements:** 600 MHz CPU, 128 MB RAM, 16 MB 3D card ■ **Price:** Rs 999
Web site: www.sonymusic.co.in ■ **Rating:** ★★★★★